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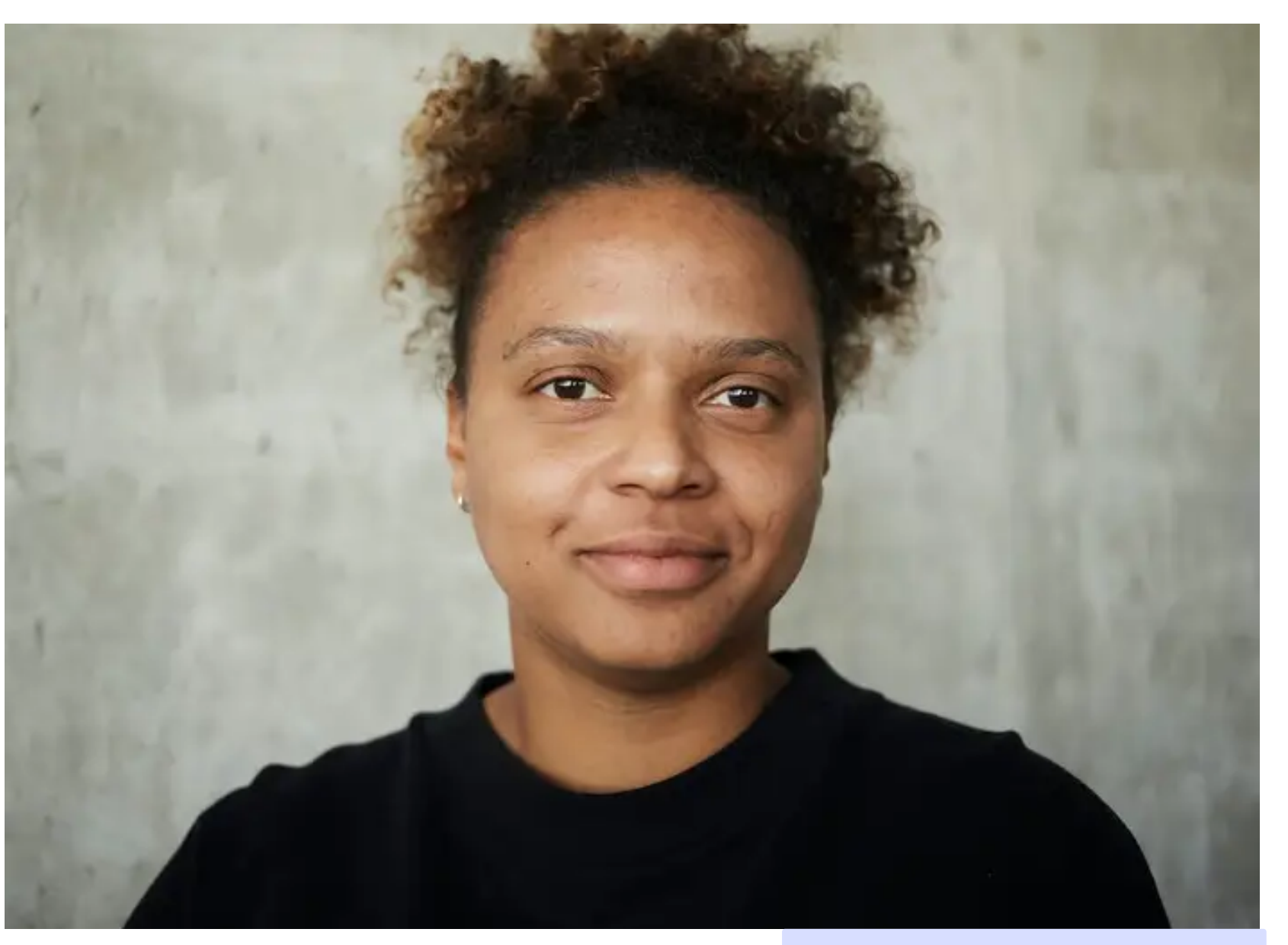
STRATEGY

A former Netflix manager says she still sees racism at work, but now uses her senior role as chief creative officer to lift marginalized voices

By Jeevan Ravindran and Hendrikje Rudnick, Business Insider Deutschland



35-year-old German managing director Dora Osinde has already had a very impres

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- Dora Osinde, chief creative officer at Berlin entertainment agency Granny, has carved her own path.
- As a woman of color Osinde has faced racism and sexism at work but uses her position to help others.
- Osinde told Business Insider Deutschland about her career, life at Granny, and tackling racism.
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35-year-old German managing director at Berlin-based entertainment agency Granny, Dora Osinde has already had an impressive career.

She was previously the creative marketing manager for Netflix, where she oversaw projects including *Dark* and *Elite*.

Osinde is now one of the four managing directors at Granny, which boasts clients such as Warner Bros., Spotify, Sky, Nike, and Netflix — but the road wasn't easy.

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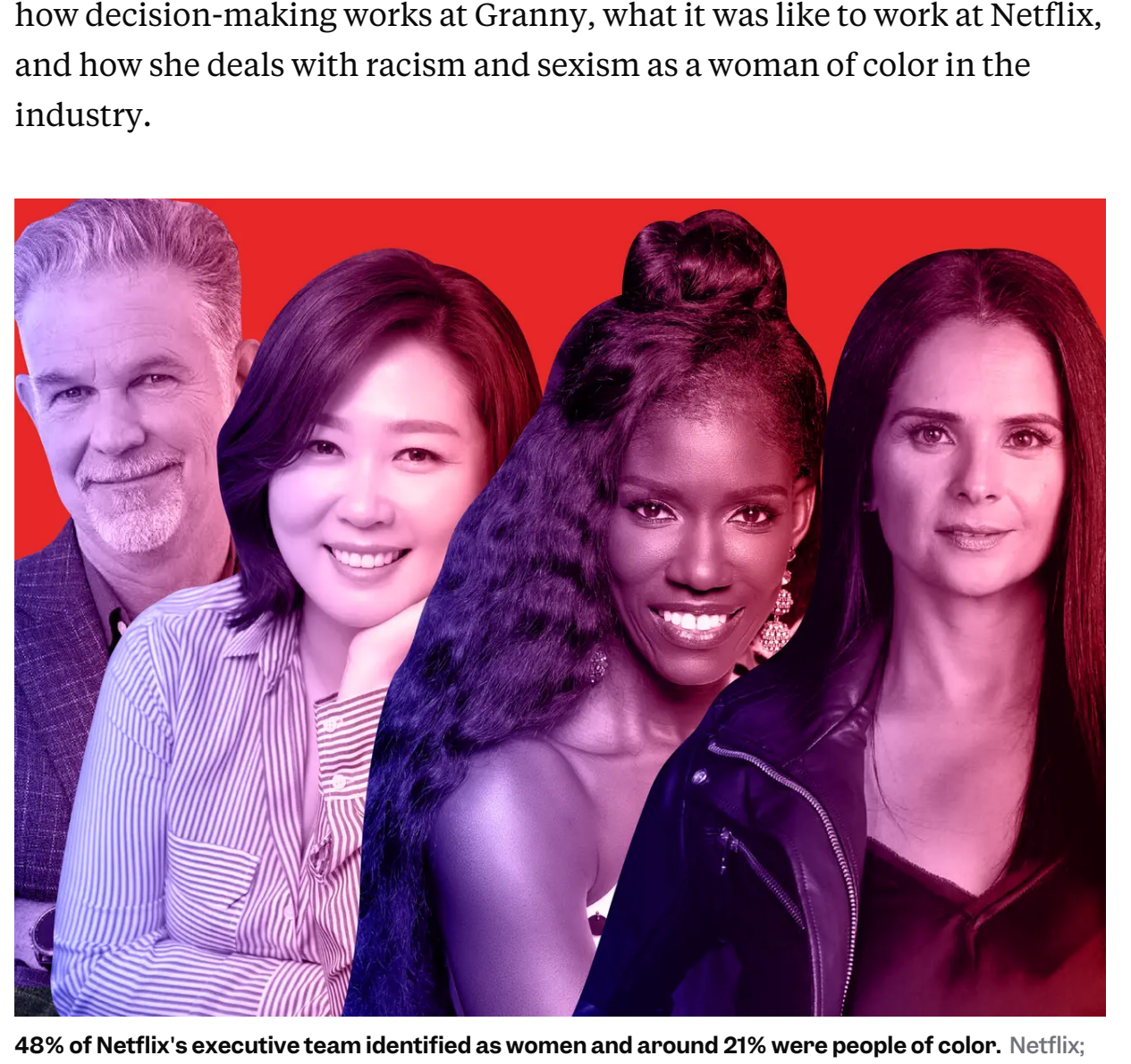
In an interview with Business Insider Deutschland, Osinde explained how decision-making works at Granny, what it was like to work at Netflix, and how she deals with racism and sexism as a woman of color in the industry.



48% of Netflix's executive team identified as women and around 21% were people of color. Netflix; Skye Gould/Insider

Teamwork makes the dream work

"It all happened very organically," Osinde said of the four-person executive team at Granny. "Each person has a specialism and says, 'Hey, I'm really good at that,' and all the skill sets complement each other. That was my experience of collaboration at Netflix too."

Netflix too relies on a larger executive team, with eight C-suite execs and 15 business heads behind most of its decisions.

48% of the group identified as women and around 21% were people of color.

Osinde previously worked at Netflix's European headquarters in Amsterdam, which she said was a "very special experience" due to the huge range of nationalities and perspectives of the workforce.

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"It was a very valuable experience for me, which also has a very positive impact on me to this day," she said.

Diversity is also important to Granny's vision.

"We're two men and two women of color, so we also have perspectives that might be neglected in other agencies and companies," Osinde said.

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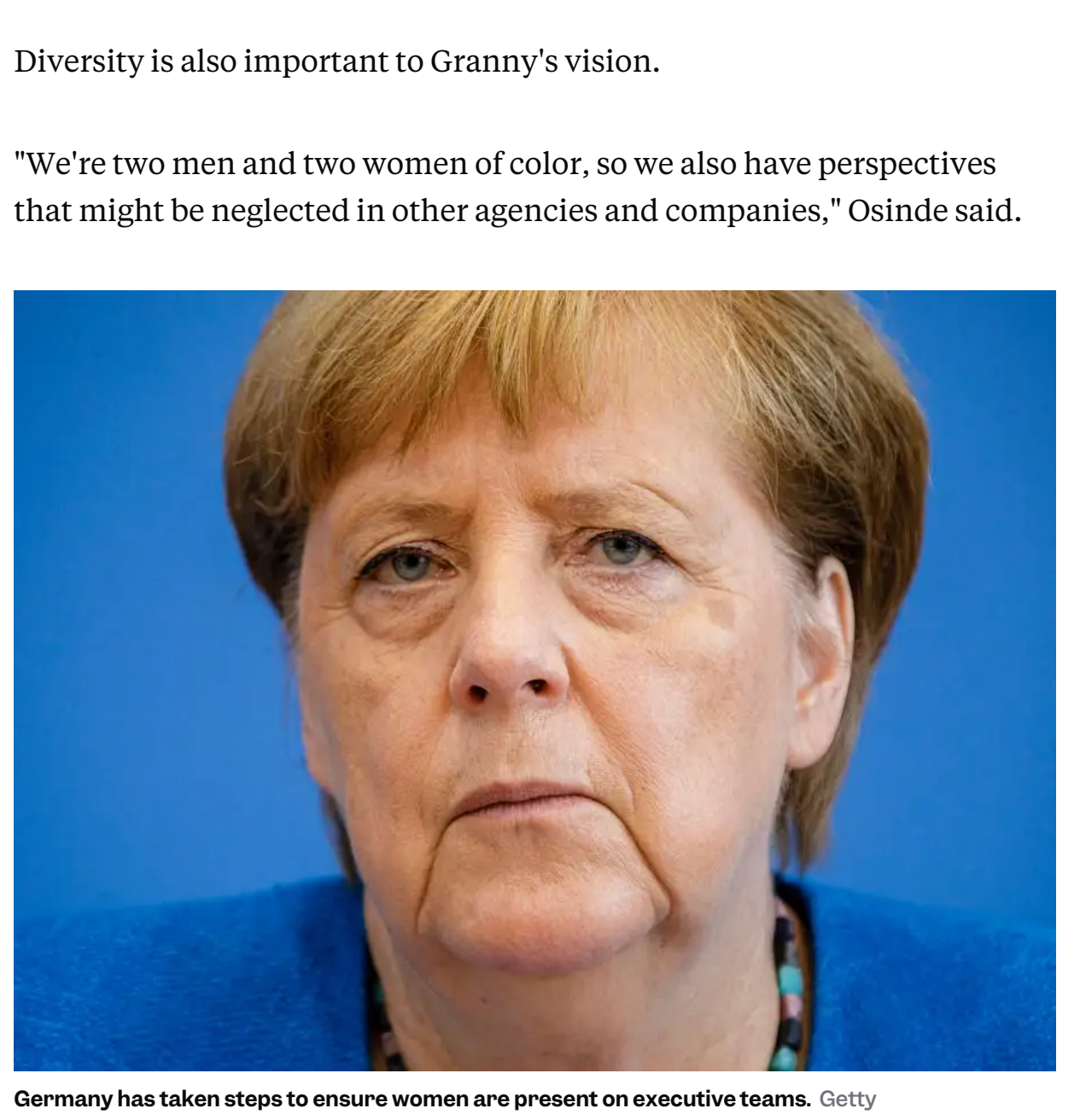

Germany has taken steps to ensure women are present on executive teams. Getty

Fostering creativity and diversity

For Osinde, the creative industry in Germany still has a way to go in terms of diversity. In particular, she has noticed a lack of diversity where new talent is concerned.

"One of the things we've experienced is that we look for people who have a suitable background for a particular topic, but the talent pool is often very lacking in diversity," she said. "This leads me to believe that many agencies and companies have perhaps not taken diversity all that seriously in the past, or that applicants feel they don't fit the job profile and therefore don't even try."

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Germany has taken steps to ensure women are present on executive teams, with any company with a team of more than three executives required to have at least one female board member.

However, no such steps have been taken for racial representation in the workplace.

Last year, German fashion retailer Zalando was accused of racism for reportedly blocking an art retailer from booking models of color for a shoot.

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"In my opinion, step one would be to create awareness among managers that diversity in the team is a huge factor in success," Osinde said. "Aside from the moral and political aspects, at Granny, we clearly see that diversity is good for business."

This commitment to diversity has led to concrete results for Granny.

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"In 2020 in particular, we have received increased feedback from clients that they chose us precisely because we have a diverse management team and a diverse team," Osinde pointed out. "Before major projects or pitches, many of them now ask us specifically what our position is on the subject."

Being a woman of color in the workplace

"I feel that, as a woman of color, you're considered less educated and less competent than you actually are," Osinde said. "In some cases, you are also considered younger and less experienced than you actually are. I remember a situation where my supervisor thought I was only 25 even though I was already in my thirties."

A report by LeanIn.org and McKinsey found that women of color made up just 4% of C-suite executives in 2019.

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White women made up 18% while white men dominated with 68%.

The pandemic has also exacerbated gender inequality, with 27% of women-run businesses closing compared to 20% run by men.

"Of course I want to walk into a new situation and not assume that my counterpart's behavior is due to racism or sexism. But if similar things happen to you 15 or 20 times, yes, a pattern is already showing up there," Osinde said. "Because it can't always be because I wasn't friendly or didn't say anything clever."

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Black women, in particular, are often subjected to tone policing — i.e. being made to feel that they have delivered a comment in an angry or unreasonable way. They are also made to feel afraid of occupying space in the workplace.

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"Sometimes I feel that as a woman of color I have to prove that I'm just as competent, experienced, and educated as everyone else in the room," Osinde said.

"Especially when it comes to racism and sexism, you often try not to offend the person who offended you," she added. "You try to remain nice and polite anyway because that's what you're taught as a woman: 'Don't make a fuss now.'"

However, Osinde said she realized later that her executive position gave her power and influence to pave the way for others, which she also did at Netflix by prioritizing marginalized voices.

"I realized that I could contribute something with my position, friendliness, and warmth that would help the person — and hopefully many other people — who will come after me," she said.

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